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Gender and Travel Writing in India, c.1650–1700

Prasun Chatterjee

Finally, all the Orientals are very much of our taste in matters of whiteness, and I have always remarked that they prefer the whitest pearls, the whitest diamonds, the whitest bread, and *the whitest women*.

– Tavernier¹

In the travel narratives of the late seventeenth century, incidents involving gender relations appear regularly; sometimes the travel/author² narrates them in order to depict these relations, while in other instances, the tropes of gendered discourse need to be excavated from these descriptions. Through these representations in the travel narratives, this essay investigates the intricacies of the gender relations where identities are constantly formed and modified, layers of meanings are created around descriptions of events, contradictions and conclusions are found in abandon, and the bridges of understanding emerge and get dissolved frequently in alterity.

In the circumstances of the paucity of the female voice and its representation in the seventeenth-century sources of the subcontinent,³ European travel narratives present several cases of women in their everyday life and activities in diverse frames. In the descriptions of the travel/author, images of women in various spheres of activities are seen to emerge as snapshots – at times linked to the context of the narration of incidents and at other times as disjointed memories – providing us with several instances to analyse the gender dimensions of the seventeenth century in the subcontinent. So, utilising the travel narratives to explore seventeenth-century gender relations would mean taking into account the sporadic nature of the descriptions which help to build up connected histories.⁴

Although there is an abundance of mention of women, there are other problems with the travel narratives. The accuracy of these events is always suspect and can hardly be verified against other sources. The subaltern activity and everyday life portrayed in these travel narratives are sporadic, appearing all of a sudden and relating these incidents in myriad ways. The anecdotes and descriptions are representations moulded by the relationship between an ‘observer’ and the ‘observed/imagined’. But then, the division of ‘observer’ and the ‘observed’ is not that simple, and is enmeshed in a complexity of networks. The travel narratives seek to present men and women and their lives, but end up representing as much about the world view and communication networks of the travel/author and fluid spaces in the

converging worlds of alterity. A careful study of these narratives brings forth questions about the veracity of neat categories of the sexes, and also the various implications embedded in the descriptions of the non-gendered. The exploration of gender relations through the voice of the travel/author – liminal due to their distance from their own culture and for being situated in alterity – shows the ways in which roles and features in gendered paradigms can shift rapidly. The layered-ness of gender emerges not only in the incidents described by the travel/author involving human actions, but also through the ‘descriptions’ of spaces and structures relating to the location of individuals or communities. The travel narratives provide descriptions and comments on gender relations in the context of several categories – castes and communities, economic stratification, and in terms of different space–time variants. These need to be analysed for a better understanding of the relation between the text, its author and the milieu.

There have been essentially two distinct epistemological concerns within which the representation of women has been studied for the seventeenth century. One of the paradigms of looking at issues is to ascertain the ‘status of women’ in a particular time period, measuring their role and contribution to the political, economic, cultural and social spheres. Another approach, a more recent one, focuses on reading the discursive text of travel narratives and literary creation in conjunction with the notions of ‘self’ and ‘other’ in the context of the events and debates in the European world. The harem, the disposition of ‘Hindu’ and ‘Muslim’ women, the ritual of *sati*, the debates on chastity and sensuality of women in the East and the West, the notions of masculinity as under-text to the description of women – all these aspects are explored within the twin concerns of sexuality and identity in this approach.

Studies to ascertain the position of women in the Mughal period try to achieve the objectivity of the actual condition in realms which were essentially spheres of male activity and have therefore been described by the chroniclers or travel/author.⁵ For example, in such a work it is mentioned, ‘Some foreign travellers such as Bernier scandalised the relation between father and daughter (*Shahjahan and Jahanara Begum*). But their statement is not reliable. Manucci says Bernier’s statement is founded on gossip of low people.’⁶ Rather than going into such attempts to uncover the ‘truth’, it would be interesting to question the larger dynamics underlying the portrayal of women by the travellers or the issues related to them in a certain manner.⁷ If they were refuted by their fellow travellers, what were the other considerations that led to the emergence of the criticism?

The epistemological shift in the last decade towards the study of representations of women and gender has led to the identification of multiple notions of ‘self’ and ‘other’.⁸ The exercise of the tropes of ‘masculine’/‘feminine’ has been the concern of recent studies.⁹ The gendered aspect of the travel narratives is brought forth through the investigation of strategies of representation of women. The sites where the hegemonising discourse seeks

to create a knowledge system to its own advantage have interested those who seek to explore dimensions of the discursive texts from a post-colonial perspective. Even though the oft-generalised arguments stemming from Edward Said's views on Orientalism have been intercepted, the attitude to formulation of binaries of representation has not yet been totally abandoned. It will be a concern of this essay to show how studies of the representational discourse often perpetuate the discourse itself by representing the binaries without looking at other marginal but significant representations of women.

Formation and Dissimulation of Categories

One of the prominent expressions of the gendered aspect of the encounter was the categorisation of spaces, their features and relations of people into a range of masculine and feminine shades, and also those which transcend these. By the mid-seventeenth century, travel/authors were exploring and describing many inland locations and routes that were new to the European reader. Fertile landscape which lies unconquered and therefore 'unappreciated' is recurrent in the description of several regions by the travellers. For instance, the image of Bengal is consistently compared with the fertile river basin of Nile and projected as stretching the earlier limits of imagination of the European world.¹⁰ The descriptions map the region as a land of fertile and 'virgin' promise coupled with the hidden perils of seductive female form by almost all the travellers of the times.¹¹

Simultaneously, a sense of the core and the periphery was developing about the conception of the subcontinent itself. For example, Bernier's narrative juxtaposes a more 'refined' sense of the woman jumping valorously on to the funeral pyre with the description of Uzbek women 'in comparison with whom the *Amazons* were soft and timorous'.¹² He uses the same trope of increasing infernality towards the periphery when he mentions that the women in Ethiopia do not 'hide themselves as in the *Indies* among the *Mahometans* and the *Gentiles*'¹³ – a situation which would have been common to that of Europe except for the huge difference that the men here 'always had two or three or more wives'.

These transmitted images were at times appropriated in European literature of the times, though they were not always true to the descriptions of the travellers. Balachandra Rajan finds that India was central in Milton's portrayal – India was no more the 'site of infernality' but its victim to the onslaught of power and cruelty.¹⁴ This is not the only picture of India painted by Milton, according to Rajan, but a significant one nevertheless. It shows the feminisation of the subcontinent had started in literary representations of the seventeenth century as well. More evidence of such dissimulation in literary representations are to be found in Dryden's play *Aureng-zebe*, often ignored for its misplaced representation of historical characters of the Mughal court. It has been suggested that Dryden was informed of Bernier's account of the subcontinent in the 1650s and 60s, and yet chose to depict the

characters of Aurangzeb and others related to the court differently from the actual happenings, to justify political developments in England in favour of the monarchy. In several characterisations and depictions within the play can be interpreted this will to conquer and feminise the Orient, in this case the subcontinent.¹⁵

The descriptions in the travel narratives not only mapped spaces as feminine or inspired spiked representations in the literary domain, but also aligned themselves to the interstices of gendered spaces. In his description of the public women of Golkunda, Tavernier describes the setting of the houses which lodged public women and the circulation of *tari*,¹⁶ and comments:

These women have so much suppleness and are so agile that when the King who reigns at present wished to visit Masulipatam, nine of them very cleverly represented the form of an elephant, four making the four feet, four others the body, and one the trunk, and the King, mounted above on a kind of throne, in that way made his entry into the town.¹⁷

This ethnographic observation about these women transcends the description of the feminine, and creates a sense of the distant and the exotic, entering the interstices within the categories of gender.

Not just through categorising feminine spaces or mapping the body, but we also find the interplay of gender in 'mapping geographies' of the subcontinent among the late seventeenth-century travel/authors. Gillian Rose has indicated the patriarchal mind-set inherent in the process of mapping.¹⁸ The female travel/authors' descriptions focused on the banal and everyday life to chart out a different course. Susan Bassnett agrees:

The history of travel writing is linked to the history of mapping and surveying. Nor was mapping restricted to geographical features: the process of mapping the natural world, of labelling flora and fauna, ran parallel to the process of mapping territories. Naming the new and labelling it became a means of marking ownership, in both physical and intellectual terms . . . new territories were metaphorised as female, as virgin lands waiting to be penetrated, ploughed, and husbanded by male explorers. The overt sexualisation of the language of territorial expansion quickly became commonplace.¹⁹

Considering the early colonial times, Bassnett's perspective on mapping supports this process and gives it an orientation towards the process of feminisation of the subcontinent. While part of the discourse in these travel narratives gravitated towards this process, as we have seen earlier, the effort of mastering and organising the newly found knowledge by the travel/author is also linked to his/her 'set of mental maps, usually fuzzy and unsystematic, and full of gaps, often also dogmatic and condescending'.²⁰ In many ways, the travel/authors of the pre-colonial period were liminal themselves, trying to gain control of their circumstances in their narratives.²¹

In the seventeenth-century travel narratives, unlike the differences bet-

ween masculine/feminine mapping discussed by Rose and Bassnett for the early modern period, we find that the travel/author hardly mentioned exact coordinates or location except delineating the prominent routes or places. The 'mapping' happened through statements about behavioural patterns and observations on nature and culture, and, often, in terms of comparisons and negations. For example, while providing a description of the significance of the political manoeuvres of the two daughters of Shahjahan during the war over succession, Bernier comments:

In the *Indies*, as well as in *Constantinople* and other places, the most momentous events are too often caused by the influence of the sex, although the people may be ignorant of this fact, and may indulge in vain speculations as to the cause of the agitation they deplore.²²

When Thevenot describes Delhi, he sets it apart from the neighbouring – and at that time equally significant – Agra. He utilises the gendered terrain to map the cities in these words:

The Painters of *Dehly* are modester than those of Agra, and spend not their pains about *lascivious Pictures*, as they do. They apply themselves to the representing of Histories, and in many places, one may meet with the Battels and Victories of their Princes . . . Order is observed in them.²³

Pre-colonial mapping happened also in terms of categorisation of the characteristics of women on the basis of religious communities or castes – an aspect we will discuss further in this essay.

So, while cartographic mapping of the subcontinent was going through a process of submerging into a common cartographic whole by the end of the seventeenth and early eighteenth centuries,²⁴ equally powerful processes of mapping through categorisations and dissumulations were at work. These fluid processes of ascription of behavioural or anatomical features to people and regions, and their categorisation in gendered terms created associations that at times reinforced and at other times ran contradictory to each other.

Notions of Masculinity and Femininity

By the mid-seventeenth century, the subcontinent is no more a distant, exotic place, and the travel/authors choose to frequently depict incidents to embed notions of morality and authority, bringing them nearer to the European imagination. The notions of masculinity and morality that had developed from the time of Akbar regarding women's roles became more circumscribed in terms of their activities in the court or statecraft²⁵ by the late sixteenth century. Bernier mentions an incident at the time of his visit where the ruler of Golconda admonished his sister for 'criminally connecting with two or three of the crew' while on a Dutch vessel on her trip back to the subcontinent from Mecca, and alleged that 'her conduct on board the Dutch vessel which conveyed her to *Moka* was unbecoming of both her sex and

rank'.²⁶ Manucci narrates the incident of Izzat Khan, the governor of Thatta, being found in the house of an inhabitant of the region dressed as a woman, and the humiliation that followed leading to his being recalled to Lahore by Aurangzeb.²⁷ Several descriptions appear in the travel narratives which portray such masculine-feminine norms. Balachandra Rajan captures the shift well in his remark regarding contemporary English literature, that this was to transform the amazons of medieval European imagination, of warrior princesses such as in *Orlando Furioso*, into the passively adoring wife of Morat (Murad), impossibly named Melesinda, who ends up in an act of self-effacement through 'suttee' in Dryden's contemporary play *Aurenge-zebe*.²⁸

The cosmological universe within which the creation of the women in the subcontinent takes place, and the picture which evolves of their inclination and condition are tainted with the 'idea of man as heroic risk-taking traveller'. This is an attitude which can be seen as 'a manifestation of the adventure quest in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, when men journeyed in search of fortune and renown to the new worlds that were opening up beyond the frontiers of Europe'.²⁹ Meandering along the difficult paths of exploration in alterity, the European imagination of travel became increasingly a means for the male travellers to discover more about their own masculinity. The male travel/author often staked claim to being able to 'penetrate' the truth better than their contemporaries and 'lay bare' the elements of the 'described' in front of their readers.³⁰ First, the psycho-sexual orientation from which these expressions emerged point towards the choice of a 'stronger' masculine sense of self against a more 'passive' object of 'description', but whether this sense of the 'masculine' is stable or breaks down at crucial junctures is another matter altogether. Second, the increasing significance of being the author of printed texts in the European world led the male travel/author to compete for claims of 'accuracy' and 'truth'.³¹ Manucci, Tavernier or Bernier, all had the propensity to publish,³² their work and also made authoritarian claims to have been more accurate than their contemporaries. As will be evident in the incidents discussed below, the convergence of the embedded notions of gender and the opportunity to depict these images of the subcontinent led the travel/authors to seek control over their narrative on alterity.

For their readers and for their own sense of self, the seventeenth-century travel/author modelled himself as a heroic figure and in the process tried to define his masculinity in the travels in alterity, a process which affected his perspective and his descriptions. Manucci describes his successful treatment of the wife of the *qazi* in Lahore who was on her deathbed and could not be cured by anyone in the city, and then articulates this achievement by saying, 'there began to be talk of the Farangi doctor who was capable of resuscitating the dead'.³³ At another place, he is successfully able to confront and conquer the temptation put to him by the Portuguese women or the women at the harem of Shah Alam.³⁴ Similarly, most of our travel/authors of

the late seventeenth century, at some juncture in their narratives, are seen to express their 'self' in this manner. Bernier recounts how he saved a woman from becoming *sati*.³⁵

This was linked to the perceptions of gender categories in early modern Europe. Kate Teltscher has pointed out that the debate over the women's question reached its climax in Europe during 1550–1640, providing the ground for travel/authors to discover a set of feminine types in other cultures.³⁶ While not entirely governed by this, when addressing issues of morality and norms for the feminine that we have seen earlier, the travel/authors would also have been aware of these developments and the need to address these questions for their readers.

It is therefore not an unconnected discourse in which the fertility of Indian women in comparison to their European counterparts is repeatedly referred to by several of these travel authors. 'Women are easily delivered of their children and sometimes they'll walk about the Streets next day after they have been brought to Bed'.³⁷ Manucci, describing an event of a nine-year-old girl giving birth to a male infant, mentions that though this would seem improbable in Europe, 'this [early child-bearing] was, nevertheless, not impossible, more especially in India, where the climate is so hot. There even the nobles are forced to go about with a simple *cabaya*'.³⁸ The environment of the subcontinent is referred to as attendant in this process of extreme fertility, thus in a way turning everything indigenous into an extension of the feminine.

Attending to the complaints of nuns in Europe, the Abbe Carre compares their condition with the harem, and enumerates their liberty and comfort in comparison to the latter. On the other hand, in a conversation with a governor of Raybag, he extols the virtue of the European women in the convents and claims a higher moral ground.³⁹ The condition of European women and nuns in particular is justified by their comparison with women in the subcontinent and not with male counterparts in their own context, where, for sure, they would have been found to be in a state of disadvantage.

The travel/authors do not just look for the masculine and the feminine, they also notice and mention the presence of eunuchs in various spheres of life. Most often the references are to their being non-sexed with no family or household, and therefore they were trusted in spaces with proximity to women.⁴⁰ Bernier mentions that it was women and eunuchs – 'whose minds are debased by the very nature of their occupation' – who would train the princes in the seraglio from infancy. Eunuchs were trusted to guard the women of the seraglio. However, fear of the non-gendered as grotesque emerges in the actions and beliefs of the men and women of the subcontinent as well as in the travel/authors' descriptions of them. For example, Bernier observes:

Emasculation, say the *Indians*, produces a different effect upon men than

upon the brute creation; it renders the latter gentle and tractable; but who is the eunuch, they ask, that is not vicious, arrogant and cruel? It is in vain to deny, however, that many among them are exceedingly faithful, generous and brave.⁴¹

The Harem and Women of Nobility

The harem in Mughal India has been a significant location of the European representation of the subcontinent.⁴² During the seventeenth century, it was the site of complex relationships and multiple identities being shaped – a site for the travel/author to create a position of prominence from their liminal space at the margins of alterity, to gain prominence in the eyes of the readers at home, for the women of the harem to exist in the imagination and fascination of the travel/author and the European people, and also for these same women to invert the ‘gaze’ and look upon their position as that of power.

The Mughal harem has been considered to be more organised than that of the Turkish and Lodi sultans.⁴³ It was also a great melting-pot of cultures, as the travel/authors remark that women of various communities cohabited the seraglio of the emperor.⁴⁴ There were eunuchs from several parts of the world who protected the seraglio or served there, there were slaves and half-slaves including the Portuguese⁴⁵ settled in the subcontinent, and there were women from several parts of the world. Bernier observes the importance of marriage alliances in the Mughal political culture when he remarks: ‘although these Kings are Mahometans, they do not scruple to marry upto heathen families, when such a measure may promote their interests, or when they may thus obtain a beautiful wife’.⁴⁶

Several seventeenth-century travel narratives attest that ladies of the royalty enjoyed some dignity of position and could recommend petitions of nobles to the emperor.⁴⁷ They were often given titles to enhance their prestige, which is reflected in titles such as Nur Mahal (Light of the *mahal*) who later became Nur Jahan (Light of the World). Jahanara was called by the name of Padshah Begum, a title that was later given to Aurangzeb’s second daughter, Zinatunnisa.⁴⁸ These titles – along with the organisation of spatial hierarchy and other customs – were a part of the power structure which went on to enhance the symbolic capital of the Mughal court.⁴⁹ The travel narratives invariably attach importance to information of this kind as projecting the grandeur of the court was a consistent feature of projecting the Mughal State as one of the most significant Asian powers of the time.

Travel/authors who would often try to form an estimate of the wealth in the Mughal realm frequently mention the wealth of the women of the harem and the nobility. The women often received their allowances half in cash and the other half as revenue from *jagirs* granted to them which were called ‘*burg-bah*’.⁵⁰ Women of the royal harem also engaged in commercial activities.⁵¹ Mariam-uz-zamani’s fleet and her overseas business ventures are well-known. Manucci relates the event of her capture and eventual release from

the Portuguese in a detailed account.⁵² Jahanara had several *jagirs* including that of Surat and her annual income was near three million rupees per year.⁵³ The sense of power and wealth of the Mughal State was therefore transmitted to the European audience not just through relating the riches of the court and the nobles, but also through images of the women of the harem. The travel narratives present the recreational and celebratory activities of the women of the harem – celebration of *nauroz*, *diwali* and other festivals, or the revelry of *Meena Bazaar* – as part of the exotic and the grandiose meant to attract the attention of the contemporary reader.

The harem in the subcontinent therefore did not invoke only the imagery of pleasure and retirement that constantly resonate in modern-day analyses of the *seraglio*. Women and children of the *mansabdar(s)* were kept in the harem and became a part of the power politics at the Mughal court. Bernier mentions an incident when Mir Jumla was in Bengal subjugating Shuja's armies. Mir Jumla requested that his family be sent to him. Aurangzeb sent to the *mansabdar* his wife and daughter, together with his son's children – which in itself was a grand gesture; however, he held on to Mir Jumla's son as assurance that Mir Jumla would not try to claim sovereignty in Bengal.⁵⁴

In the descriptions of the travel/authors, women of the *seraglio* are not only subjects of court politics but also active participants in the various manoeuvres. According to Rekha Misra, women of the Mughal and Turkish harem 'did enjoy some political privileges'.⁵⁵ However, it should be kept in mind that among these women, only a few women of the royalty who were close to the seat of power enjoyed such 'privileges' and they were a miniscule segment. Bernier⁵⁶ and Manucci,⁵⁷ both mention the significance of women like Jahanara Begum during the reign of Shahjahan and Roshanara Begum during that of Aurangzeb. From such depictions of women in positions of power influencing State policies,⁵⁸ the descriptions often verge on the other extreme of images of powerful and rich wives of the *mansabdars* who participated in a decadent atmosphere of luxury with the emperor. For example, Bernier mentions that the wife of Shaista Khan, a relative of Aurangzeb, 'happened to be then at court, and never ceased to urge the arrest of a man who had killed her son, wounded her husband, and sacked *Sourate*'. This, according to Bernier, was one of the reasons for Shivaji's imprisonment. He goes on to say that when Shivaji escaped, a theory was floating around that Aurangzeb himself was a party to the escape 'since the hatred of these women was most fierce and rancorous against him'.⁵⁹ As mentioned earlier, the veracity of these accounts is extremely problematic. For us, it is more important to appreciate the space occupied by these women, depicting images beyond the dominant idea of the harem as a closed space.

In the travel narratives, we find a constant interplay of the 'gaze'. In the accounts of the European travellers, the harem is a place of lasciviousness and sensuality.⁶⁰ The male gaze is turned on the imagination of the space as

they could rarely access it. So, every anecdote related to the harem is transmitted to the European reader. Francois Bernier entered the seraglio, his eyes covered with a scarf; he was led inside the harem 'like a blind man' by a eunuch. The traveller is therefore unable to describe the harem at the fort of Delhi: 'I now wish I could lead you about in the Seraglio, as I have done in the rest of the Fortress: But who is the Traveller that can speak of that as an eyewitness?'⁶¹ Since the claim of being an eyewitness is crucial to the authority of a travel writer, this is an expression of authorial impotence.⁶² Along with this, Bernier here recognises the seraglio as a coveted site of power.

The seraglio also becomes a site where the 'gaze' is inverted. Manucci⁶³ mentions several times that the women would feign illness to meet them, or show their jewellery to strike up a conversation. Following Baudrillard's formulation of seduction⁶⁴ as a form of power wielded through signs and rituals, Manucci's remarks about the late seventeenth-century women – 'for I have noticed several times myself when introduced into the rooms of these ladies, they having asserted that they had some reason for consulting me that they often cause their ornaments and jewels to be brought, solely as an opening for a conversation'⁶⁵ – show anxiety at losing control and being led into a world inverted from the outside where women watched and schemed for male attention. Tavernier describes the popularity of the young Dutch physician, M. Pitre de Lan, among the royal ladies after he had skilfully bled (bleeding was a standard practice employed by European physicians to let out bad blood) the King of Golkunda to good health.

The young Queen and the Queen-dowager having heard of it, desired that he would bleed them also, *but I believe it was more from the curiosity they had to see him than for any need they had to be bled, for he was a young and well-made man, and probably in their lives they had not seen a stranger at close quarters* – for from a distance this is not impossible, since from the place where they stay they are able to see without being themselves seen.⁶⁶

John Fryer describes this inversion when, during his visit as a physician to a harem, the curtain falls accidentally and the women 'fluttering like so many Birds . . . but feigning a shamefacedness, continued looking through the wide Lattice of their Fingers . . .'.⁶⁷ His juxtaposition of the expression 'fluttering like birds' with the persistent gaze of the women presents a situation where the multiple layers in the gender relations at these sites come to the fore.

The significance of the harem for the travel/author as the observer and the 'turning of the gaze' during their visits inside show the dynamic interplay over this site, rather than the harem being only a category of description of women. The travel/author seeks to become important in the eyes of the European reader through his description of the harem; this endeavour brings its own perils as at the same time he loses control, and his authoritative stance is replaced by the feeling of becoming the 'observed'.

Women across the Religious Divide

There has been a tendency in scholarship for the images of women portrayed by the seventeenth-century texts to be interpreted in terms of a Hindu–Muslim religious divide. For instance:

Unlike the ‘Woman Question’ polemicists, travel writers only occasionally generalise about the sex as a whole, tending rather to categorise Indian women according to their religious affiliation, Muslim or Hindu. Writers frequently represent Muslim and Hindu women as complementary opposites, ignoring any distinctions between the different Hindu castes.⁶⁸

However, in the next few pages of *India Inscribed*, Teltscher, while describing the women of the harem and those ‘outside’, creates the same boundaries as his sources and remarks: ‘The menacing aspect of female sexuality is even more apparent in the accounts of Hindu women.’⁶⁹ Another statement that shows this binary conception is: ‘This sense of Indian female otherness, both Muslim and Hindu, is heightened by their respective areas of sexual mythology: the secret harem and Hinduism’s occult sexual practices.’⁷⁰ First, it is important to dispel the notion that harem women were only Muslim. Several women in the harem were non-Muslim and some were also Hindu, so the depiction of the licentiousness of harem women is also a description of Hindu women. For example, the following description of the harem does not specify the community to which the women belong:

There are some (women in the harem) who from time to time affect the invalid, simply that they may have the chance of some conversation with, and have their pulse felt by, the physician who comes to see them. The latter stretches out his hand inside the curtain; they lay hold of it, kiss it, and softly bite it. Some, out of curiosity, apply it to their breast, which has happened to me several times; but I pretended not to notice, in order to conceal what was passing from the matrons and eunuchs then present, and not arouse their suspicions.⁷¹

Second, while portraying a ‘sense of Indian female otherness’, the travel/author does not mention the ‘secret harem’ mythology as the behavioural pattern of Muslims. Also, several Hindu raja(s) of the time too had their own harems, some of which find mention in various sources. Finally, the descriptions of the travel/authors are too disparate to be brought into one frame where their description of the ‘Indian female otherness’ can be put into just two plain categories of myth-making.

The travel/authors wrote in different contexts, and according to their individual views and needs. Bernier’s focus was on the Mughal court, and therefore he encountered women of categories mostly in and around this context. Tavernier travelled six times to the subcontinent and his observations assimilate much more of the cultural diversity, describing women in various other settings which were essentially not driven by their religious

orientation. Manucci's travels and anecdotes encompassed much wider swathes of the subcontinent; a significant section of his narrative describes Portuguese women and women of different regions and castes.

Then, it needs to be realised there is almost an essential presence of the 'sensuality' sought by the 'male gaze' in the travel writings on the subcontinent, which is also a method of gaining power by the travel/author over the observed as well as the reader. The common perception regarding this sensuality has been to divide the understanding into Muslim and Hindu woman. In his description of a visit to the harem, Manucci remarks: 'All the world knows that the Mahomedans, following the example of their master, Muhammad, are very licentious; wherefore there are men among them, some more and some less, chiefly the nobles and the kings, who do not content themselves with it.'⁷²

If this description is compared with the attitude of the one about the incidents relating to a sect in a Hindu temple, it has hardly any difference in terms of its purpose. Manucci provides his readers with an equally sensual and exotic account of the religious practices of the sect of 'the Multipliers', at Trimbak village near Nasik district, when he was travelling there as Raja Jai Singh's envoy. Here, he provides a detailed account of the orgiastic practices of the sect devised by a Brahman who had become obsessed with a married woman.⁷³ Fantasies, whether that of the harem or of religious sexuality,⁷⁴ are as much to inform the readers of the exotic 'otherness' of the subcontinent as to obtain the power to seduce the readers.

A third dimension of this problem is of considering gender and religion-related binaries to be constant in the travel narratives. Reading within a text often diffuses such assumed binaries; for example, let us take the oft-repeated comments of Manucci, Bernier or Tavernier about Muhammadans who 'have only one idea of recreation, that of having the pleasure of the company of the harem women'. 'Although the women in the *mahal* treat themselves so sumptuously and display all the dignity that I have reported, Aurangzeb sees no harm. For all Mahomedans are very fond of women, who are their principal relaxation and almost their only pleasure.'⁷⁵ At another place in the *Storia*, the same image is created of the Hindu male when Manucci says: 'I have stated in my history that the Hindus know no higher delight in the world than consorting with women.'⁷⁶ Such incongruencies also take place in the depiction of women across the religious divide. For example, Thevenot comments about the women of Dehly:

The Women of Dehly are handsome and the Gentiles very chaste; insomuch, that if the Mahometan Women did not by their wantonness dishonour the rest, the Chastity of the Indians might be proposed as an example to all the Women of the East. These Indian Women are easily delivered of their Children; and sometimes they'll walk about the Streets next day after they have been brought to bed.⁷⁷

Even though the accessible truth in the travel narratives is that of representation of women through labels of religious divide, there can be other means of locating these abundant remarks by the travel authors.

Debates around Images of *Sati*

The religious binary regarding the representation of women that we have considered above also permeates into debates and discussions over *sati*. In our understanding, often at one end of the Hindu–Muslim binary is the image of the harem and on the other there is the figure of the *sati*. From this underlying unitary theme emanate questions about the differences between the pre-colonial and colonial attitudes, about the autonomy of the *sati* or about the metaphors used to describe the ritual.

Lata Mani has argued that colonial discourse invariably represents the *sati* as victim. It does not allow the woman any autonomy, and she is seen to be compelled into the decision by the statutes of her religion or the coercion of males and priests who are interested in her property.⁷⁸ Kate Teltscher points out that Mani's argument is right only if considered in the colonial context, and that this was not the case in earlier European representations where the classical literary framework is adopted to depict a determined and courageous *sati*. In later constructions of the colonial regime, this option is not available since 'the colonial regime cannot undermine its own authority by elevating its subjects to the status of classical heroines'.⁷⁹

The problem here is again about the binaries of the pre-colonial and the colonial being compartmentalised. In the late seventeenth-century travel narratives, not at all times do the travel/authors relate the *sati* to the classical heroine; as we shall see, there are many more tropes that are used to describe the phenomenon. Rather, more often, while condemning the institution of *sati*, the travellers highlight a strong suspicion at the bizarre behaviour of the *sati*, and insist that the widow was administered some substance and that she was somehow being forced by the Brahmans who accompanied her. Consider Manucci's remarks:

I have seen some die with their husband's body in their arms without making a sign of movement. The reason is that the Brahmans provide them with certain beverages – *bhang* (hemp), opium, and such like, which entirely stupefy them.

Others, by use of sorcery, become eager, ardent, mad, demanding that the authorities put no hindrance in their way when in search of their beloved, alleging as a reason that they are suffering acutely from deprivation of their loved one.⁸⁰

The agency of the widow is always at question, if not undermined, at all points of time. Reluctance, and a certain amount of confusion and disbelief on the part of the travellers at the willingness of the widow to be a *sati*, is

almost always present. Teltscher identifies a clear break between the colonial and the pre-colonial discourses; however, it seems there are continuities.

If we look at the travel narratives closely, the unitary picture on which these questions are based seems to fracture. If the colonial authority had anxieties over control, the representations of the seventeenth-century travel/authors also were ridden with tensions. Andrea Major has explained that a changing European construction of womanhood and femininity meant that the values and ideas relating to *sati* had a *different* impact and *different* meanings at *different* times.⁸¹ We come across regional variations of the practice and its structure, as well as different conditions and responses of the travel/authors. Bernier's experiences were limited to in and around Agra and Delhi, and at most to northern India. He connects the more general image of the *sati* with the ethno-political etching of Rajput identity, and an incident involving Jaswant Singh's wife where she readied the funeral pile when the raja returned home defeated by Aurangzeb's army during the war of succession.⁸² He argues that the power of tradition to condition behaviour drew the widow into performing the act. Male control was ensured through female conditioning which was passed on from generation to generation.⁸³ Bernier also talks about actual social compulsion.⁸⁴ Tavernier projects a regional understanding of *sati*, and describes incidents of various regions and differences of performance. Stating that 'I have seen women burnt in three different countries', he describes the distinctions between women being burnt in the 'Kingdom of Gujarat, and as far as Agra and Delhi', in the 'Kingdom of Bengal' and 'along the coast of Coromandel'.⁸⁵ Manucci has an essentially caste-based perception (which for him is the four *varnas*) of the institution, and delineates the performance of it as a 'ceremony' like child-bearing and marriage. He describes the *sati* as a ritual performed among Brahmans, Rajahs and the Vaisyas, and discusses them separately. The Brahman widow who becomes a *sati* is represented as being seated on the pyre of her husband; the Rajput wife is depicted as jumping into a pit of fire – associated with the caste-related notion of 'honour'.⁸⁶ If this picture conveys a certain amount of adulation for the ceremony, Manucci quickly qualifies it with a description of the widow being forced into the pit if reluctant to do so.

The differences are not just in the individual experiences, but also within the narrative of a single travel/author. In the shifting terrains of alterity, the response to images kept shifting in these dynamic texts, which were not necessarily written at one go or edited for consistency of argument. For example, Manucci begins his description of a *sati* saying, 'It is *wonderful* to see what is done when any Hindu rajah or prince expires.'⁸⁷ He goes on to praise the courage of the widow: each man returns home envying the firmness and constancy which the woman has been granted the felicity of displaying.⁸⁸ But then the description turns to one of horror, 'They are soon choked by the smoke, while the men surrounding the pyre raise a noise with drums and gongs'.⁸⁹ Finally, Manucci turns to condemning the act and

invokes Christian morality to rebuke the Brahmins who initiated it: 'for in everybody else there are some evil traits, while all the rest is good; whereas in the Brahman caste, where there ought doubtless to be something good, one meets with nothing that is not entirely evil'.⁹⁰

The travel/authors also differ on the options available to a widow and the social pressures for them to become a *sati*. Describing the life of widows, Manucci remarks that they either become public courtesans or 'wait on their parents' like servants. 'Other women, when the husband dies, since it would be disgraceful in their caste to marry again, and they cannot remain as they are, go from door to door selling rice. They think nothing of this dishonour, which would be counted among Europeans as the depth of misfortune.'⁹¹ Tavernier, however, differs from Bernier and Manucci in maintaining that only childless women generally were chosen for *sati*: 'For widows who have children are not permitted under any circumstances to burn themselves with the bodies of their husbands.'⁹² Though it is very unlikely that this would have been the case at most places, as V. Ball the editor of the volume observes, differences of opinion appear on several aspects regarding *sati*.

Apart from the question over the representation of women as victims, the other point of contention is regarding a perceived transformation of *sati* into a public act in the colonial arena. Teltscher seems to agree with the perceptive remark of Gayatri Spivak that the 'leap of *suttee* from private to public has a clear and complex relationship with the changeover from a mercantile and commercial to a territorial and administrative British presence'.⁹³ The question that arises is, how does the private and the public suffer such disjunction exactly at a single point, and about the creation of a public sphere linked directly to the British presence. It is then to deny any role to the Mughal State and its efforts to resist the institution, for it was a long-standing stance that the State had taken up against this act since the time of Akbar's verdict against the institution. Bernier describes a situation where the Mughal governor tries to dissuade a woman, the wife of the late Bendidas, Danishmand Khan's principal writer, from becoming a *sati*.⁹⁴ In another instance, Tavernier mentions that a woman took permission from the governor of Vengurla to become a *sati*.⁹⁵

The 'voluntary' nature of *sati* was always at question in seventeenth-century India, in the language of the Mughal State and in the discourse of the traveller. Bernier, at one point, pegs the multiplicity of reasons for *sati* in these words: 'many wives burn themselves after the death of their husbands . . . I shall . . . show the ascendancy which prejudice, ancient habit, hope, the force of public opinion, and the principle of honour, have over the human mind.'⁹⁶

Mani's argument that 'the widow thus nowhere appears as a full subject' is applicable not just in the colonial but also in the pre-colonial context. Also, at no instance does the descriptions of the travel/authors suggest that *sati* was a private act. As we have seen above, there were several factors at work

and the act of *sati* was an act in the public sphere of the seventeenth century. There were several resisting and propelling factors instrumental during *sati* – State intervention, the influence of Brahmins and priests, the ability to obtain permission from the governor of the place, and also societal reasons such as the exclusion of women with children.

Social Stratifications in Descriptions of Gender

If we do not focus only on a connection with any larger narrative, we do come across several categories of women in the court and the harem itself beyond the dazzling descriptions of the elite. These spaces occur in the travel narratives as a part of the description of incidents and their settings.

The travel narratives observe contexts in different layers of social stratification. Thus, while describing the vain pursuit of ornaments or jewellery of the royal ladies and wives of the nobles, Manucci mentions the Central Asian female slaves as personal guards of the emperor who were the only ones responsible for his security while he was in his bedchamber at night.⁹⁷ Bernier mentions how the slaves of the Portuguese at Hugli (Bengal) were coerced by Shahjahan, and then ‘the handsome women as well married as single, became inmates of the *seraglio*; those of a more advanced age or of inferior beauty, were distributed among the *Omrahs*’.⁹⁸ The exclusive female presence in the harem is articulated in the explanation of the various posts held by the matrons and the women who acted as captains of the internal security organisation of the place.⁹⁹ In the court or the harem, there were a caste of women called *kanchanis* who danced for the emperor and the courtiers.¹⁰⁰ Therefore, the descriptions of the elite would not have taken the hue of splendour as in the travel/authors’ transmission of the images without detailing the setting where women of the lower strata were the most prominent presence. A description of the *Meena Bazaar* of Shahjahan is given in the travel narratives which says that the emperor could take a fascination to any woman – suggesting that women of the lower strata present in the court were also within the ambit.¹⁰¹

In the same manner, the wives of soldiers are described only to explain the fact that soldiers in the subcontinent moved around with their family and belongings. Along with the soldiers moved their household comprising of their wives, their servants and, as Manucci notes, there were also slave women of African origin (he calls them *Negro*).¹⁰² Such slave women are mentioned also in the case of Portuguese society and according to Manucci, they engaged in magic arts.¹⁰³

Tavernier and Bernier,¹⁰⁴ both describe the condition of women who did not perform *sati* as dismal. Some of them sold rice. Manucci compares the situation with European widows for whom such work would mean social denigration, but then goes on to say that such work was better than being idle and yielding to the wishes of the devil.¹⁰⁵ They mention that those who went to their parents’ place were treated badly and others ended up as public women.

This is an obvious reference to the image of the European widow who was often perceived as a threat to the society with labels such as a witch, or a particular image of a sexually experienced yet frustrated female.¹⁰⁶

There are several references to public women in the travel texts. In the descriptions of courts, as has been seen in earlier sections, along with the details of court practices, army and servants of the court, descriptions are to be found of public women and courtesans in such a set-up. Tavernier recounts that during the reign of Abdulla Qutb Shah in the 1660s, there were 2,000 public women in Golkonda and they had to register with the *darogha*. They did not need to pay taxes but had to perform at the court on appointed days.¹⁰⁷ Noting the economic context, he mentions that the shops around this place sell *tari* from which the king derives 'a very considerable revenue'. The traveller here indicates the economic aspect of the arrangement of trade of public women as well as the related trade of liquor, both of which yielded considerable revenue for the State.

Moving from an association with trade in alcohol and revenue generation for the State, women are mentioned in ritual service to God. Bernier mentions the performance by public women at the chariot festival in Jagannath and their being controlled by the Brahmans associated with the temple.¹⁰⁸ Unaware of the history of *devadasis*' journey from the temple to the court of the Nayakas, Tavernier discusses the different education that the girls who were to become *devadasis* received from the usual domestic work in which other girls of the time had to be trained, and mentions that they were taken to a temple in Cambay for worship when they reached puberty.¹⁰⁹ He compares the God at the temple with a Greek god, invoking antiquarian imagery of the Greco-Roman past and appealing to the sensibilities of post-Renaissance Europe. At the same time, they also allude to the exploitation of these women by Brahman priests and invoke the intransigence of the new spaces. Antiquarianism and the novelty of unknown spaces merge to create a powerful position for the travel/author as the transmitter of this knowledge.

The descriptions of the new regions being explored or heard about are accompanied by remarks about the women and households in those regions. These ethnographic observations were creating a corpus of characteristic traits of communities, which would amalgamate into the European discourse of the colonial times. Manucci projects the women of Assam as ideal wives and of acceptable demeanour. He states: 'The natives of those lands take four wives. Here the women are very lovely, and they do all the work of the house, the men being indolent, except in war-time, when they all go forth to fight.'¹¹⁰

The mapping of these new spaces was accompanied by categorisation of the feminine/masculine, apart from snapshots of women in various occupational and household activities. Bengal's image as a region of immense possibilities, unexplored hidden treasures of land and resources, and exceptional fertility¹¹¹ is compounded with the depiction of unseen dangers of

female sexuality. Projecting it as a region of high fortunes but fraught with equally imminent dangers, instead of the woman in the house, the travel narratives highlight the *sangueny* (*sankhini*), the witches in forests, who attracted men by fires in the night and made them fall in love with their beauty. Manucci, perhaps from folklore, picks only this representation of women from the region, and that along with the dense forests of the Sunderbans and the wild animals becomes the visible image of the region.¹¹²

Another region which assumes a clear character in the depiction of the travellers is Kashmir. Bernier was as taken in by the beauty of the landscape as by descriptions of the beauty of the inhabitants of the valley. He describes his fascination at watching the women who generally remained within purdah, and this caters to the allure of the male gaze in the description he provides of the women of the region.¹¹³

At certain junctures, the travel narratives incorporated local history or anecdotes while describing the characteristics of a region. Recounting a story from the first decade of the seventeenth century, Manucci provides an emphatic account of the bravery and moral strength of the Marava women of Madura. His account extols the grit and resolve shown by these women to provoke the men of the community by not providing them any services in the household, leading them to avenge the defeat of their Nayaka ruler at the hands of the Madura prince.¹¹⁴ As William Irvine's corroboration with other sources of the region shows, this is an event where the travel/author mixes history with hearsay and creates an attractive image that clearly etches the region through statements like: 'These Marava women are very brave and faithful to their husbands.' Manucci follows up this piece of 'history' with another account of his own time where these qualities are reinforced. Here, in describing an incident where a Marava woman saves herself and her child from an amorous fakir,¹¹⁵ leading to the persecution of all fakirs in that territory,¹¹⁶ the travel/author plays with the normative image of fakirs and dervishes as being lustful to further inscribe the quality of the women and the characteristics of the region. Interestingly, in the whole episode spanning some four pages, he does not make a single comment on the behaviour of the Marava male. Either it is a given that the male counterpart of such brave females of a community must be as courageous, or, on the other hand, the men of the community do not resist as valiantly until their women challenge their gender role.

Converging and Conflicting Images

The travels and descriptions of the travel/authors had become more extensive by the late seventeenth century. The range of images exploring gender relations, at times converging and at other times conflicting, became even more diverse. So, on the one hand, we encounter remarks and narrations that seek to gain control and project a masculine self. The metaphors used

were familiar to the European readers who now followed the increasing proximity of 'other' worlds with great interest.¹¹⁷ Simultaneously, in several situations the interstices of the gendered matrix emerged from the apparent binaries of masculine–feminine or the religious divide. To explore beyond the compartmentalised categories and excavate the interplay of rhetoric and description, we would need to understand the narration of the travel/authors in terms of their specific experiences as well as the entirety of their texts.

Notes and References

- 1 Tavernier, *Travels in India*, edited by William Crooke, second edition, 1925, Vol. 2, p. 91.
- 2 I use this term to indicate the multiple layers in the identities of the writers of the travel narratives. The first form 'travel' denotes the propensity to be liminal, to be able to experience from the 'outside' as a travel-ler. The second form, of 'author' brings to the fore the intention to create representations for a perceived audience – an identity that binds and stratifies the notions of travel and description – and for the printed form.
- 3 Rekha Misra, *Women in Mughal India (1526–1748 AD)*, 1967, p. v.
- 4 See Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *Explorations in Connected History*, 2 vols., 2005.
- 5 'The status of women in a country represents fairly the social spirit of the age.' See Rekha Misra, *Women in Mughal India*, p. v.
- 6 Ibid., p. 42, fn. 5.
- 7 In another instance, Rekha Misra reacts to the statement by Manucci that Jahanara Begum liked drinking along with the other ladies of the harem by saying: 'This statement of Manucci creates doubt whether a lady of pious inclination like that of Jahanara could be fond of drinking.' Ibid., p. 85.
- 8 See Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *Three Ways of Being Alien*, 2011.
- 9 See, for example, Rosalind O' Hanlon, 'Kingdom, Household and Body: History, Gender and Imperial Service under Akbar', *MAS*, 41 (5), 2007, pp. 889–923.
- 10 Bernier, *Travels in the Mogul Empire AD 1656-1668*, edited by V. Smith, second edition, 1934, pp. 437–46.
- 11 Ibid., p. 202.
- 12 Ibid., p. 122. Also see Manucci's description of the Tartar and Uzbek women from Balkh: Manucci, *Storia do Mogor*, edited by W. Irvine, 1907–08, Vol. 2, p. 38.
- 13 Bernier, *Travels*, pp. 142–43.
- 14 Balachandran Rajan, *Under Western Eyes: India from Milton to Macaulay*, 1999, pp. 56–57.
- 15 Ibid., p. 72.
- 16 Alcohol created from the juice of coconut palm.
- 17 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 1, pp. 127–28; similar imagery is presented in Bernier, *Travels*, p. 306.
- 18 See Susan Bassnett, 'Travel Writing and Gender', in *The Cambridge Companion to Travel Writing*, 2002, p. 230; and Gillian Rose, *Feminism and Geography: The Limits of Geographical Knowledge*, 1993.
- 19 Susan Bassnett, 'Travel Writing and Gender', p. 231.
- 20 David Shulman, 'Foreword', in Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *Three Ways to Be Alien*, 2011, p. ix.
- 21 See Natalie Z. Davis, *The Return of Martin Guerre*, 1983; *Trickster Travels: A Sixteenth-century Muslim between Worlds*, 2007.

- 22 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 16.
- 23 Thevenot, *The Indian Travels of Thevenot and Careri*, edited by S.N. Sen, 1949, p. 65.
- 24 Mathew H. Edney, *Mapping an empire: the geographical construction of British India, 1765-1843*, 1997, pp. 3-9.
- 25 Rosalind O'Hanlon, 'Kingdom, Household and Body: History, Gender and Imperial Service under Akbar', *MAS*, 41, 5, 2007, pp. 889-923.
- 26 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 197.
- 27 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, pp. 205-06.
- 28 See Balachandran Rajan, *Under Western Eyes*, p. 21.
- 29 See Susan Bassnett, 'Travel Writing and Gender', p. 225.
- 30 For example, consider the claim of Manucci that he had access inside the harem and his criticism of the inaccuracy of Bernier's description of the practices in the house of Begum Sahib. Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, pp. 211-12.
- 31 For a similar formulation for the colonial period, see Sara Mills, *Discourses of Difference*, 1991, p. 21. She points out the less authoritarian stance taken by the woman travel writer vis-à-vis the narrative voice.
- 32 Bernier's and Tavernier's texts went into several editions, Manucci's manuscript had a much more tortuous journey. See Subrahmanyam, *Three Ways to Be Alien*, pp. 154-60, and W. Irvine, 'Introduction', *Storia do Mogor*, Vol. I.
- 33 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 166.
- 34 *Ibid.*, pp. 373-74.
- 35 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 306.
- 36 Kate Teltscher, 'Indian Women: The Seventeenth-Century European Fantasy', in *India Inscribed: European and British Writing on India, 1600-1800*, 1995, p. 35.
- 37 Thevenot, *Indian Travels of Thevenot and Careri*, edited by S.N. Sen, p. 66. Almost all foreign travellers bear testimony to child marriages in India (p. 72, fn. 5), according to Sen.
- 38 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 202.
- 39 Abbe Carre, *Travels of Abbe Carre in India and the North East, 1672-74*, Vol. 1, 1947, p. 261.
- 40 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 1, pp. 88-89.
- 41 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 132.
- 42 Rana Kabbani, *Europe's Myths of Orient*, 1986, p. 18.
- 43 Rekha Misra, *Women in Mughal India*, p. 11.
- 44 Manucci mentions how the Uzbek woman Yakshi was placed with the numerous Kashghar, Qalmaq, Pathan and Abyssinian women, who acted as sentinels round the king at night. Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 38.
- 45 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 132.
- 46 *Ibid.*, p. 126.
- 47 *Ibid.*, pp. 12, 190.
- 48 Rekha Misra, *Women in Mughal India*, p. 60.
- 49 I discuss this in a section on 'Representations of Women and Mughal Political Culture' in Chapter 2 of my Ph.D. thesis, 'The Social, Economic and Cultural Conditions of Hindustan as described by Manucci', unpublished, University of Lucknow, 2005.
- 50 *Mirat-ul-istila*, Anand Ram, f.15a, quoted in Rekha Misra, *Women in Mughal India*, p. 35. The practice of granting *parganas* was started by Babur and Aurangzeb; even though he went on an economy drive after accession, he did not reduce the allowance of Jahanara.
- 51 Rekha Misra, *Women in Mughal India*, p. 71.
- 52 Ellison B. Findly, 'The Capture of Mariam-uz-Zamani's Ship: Mughal Women and

- European Traders', in Meena Bhargava, ed., *Exploring Medieval India II*, p. 264; see Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, pp. 350–51.
- 53 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol.1, p. 208.
- 54 Bernier, *Travels*, pp. 169–70.
- 55 Ibid., p. 16.
- 56 Ibid., pp. 11, 14.
- 57 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, pp. 211–12.
- 58 Teltscher, 'Indian Women', p. 45 quotes from Catrou, pp. 331–32, to show the significance of the ladies of the court. Catrou, in his edition, puts these remarks as that of Manucci, this text should be carefully used because of the interpolations by Catrou. Manucci's own text edited by William Irvine does not carry this statement.
- 59 Bernier, *Travels*, pp. 190–91. According to Vincent Smith, Fryer too narrates the same account: Fryer, *A New account of East India and Persia being nine years' travels 1672–1681*, Vol. 2, p. 65.
- 60 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, pp. 316–17; describing the life of the royal ladies of the harem, he says, 'In the midst of such idleness, enjoyment and grandeur, they cannot fail to get their minds loaded with the impurity of many vices.'
- 61 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 267.
- 62 Teltscher, 'Indian Women', p. 42.
- 63 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 329.
- 64 See Baudrillard, *Seduction*, 1979, p. 2: 'Masculinity has always been haunted by this sudden irreversibility within the feminine.'
- 65 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 316.
- 66 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 1, pp. 241–42.
- 67 Fryer, *New account of East India and Persia*, Vol. 1, p. 327.
- 68 Teltscher, 'Indian Women', pp. 37–38.
- 69 Ibid., p.45, emphasis mine.
- 70 Teltscher, 'Indian Women', p. 40.
- 71 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 329.
- 72 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 1, p. 186.
- 73 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 3, pp. 138–39.
- 74 The strain of antiquarianism here is connected to the post-Renaissance fascination with the Greek and Roman civilisations. I thank Projit Mukharji for this suggestion.
- 75 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 319.
- 76 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 3, p. 71.
- 77 Thevenot, *Indian Travels of Thevenot and Careri*, p. 66.
- 78 Lata Mani, 'The Production of an Official Discourse on Sati in early nineteenth century Bengal', in Francis Baker *et al.*, eds., *Europe and its Others*, 2 vols., Colchester, 1985, Vol. 1, pp. 107–27.
- 79 Teltscher, 'Indian Women', p. 63.
- 80 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 3, pp. 148–49; also see Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 2, pp. 169–70; Thevenot, *Indian Travels of Thevenot and Careri*, p. 120; Ovington, 344; Bernier, *Travels*, p. 306.
- 81 Andrea Major, *Pious Flames: European Encounters with Sati, 1500–1830*, 2006, p. 28.
- 82 Bernier, *Travels*, pp. 40–41.
- 83 Ibid., pp. 122–23.
- 84 Ibid., p. 126.
- 85 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 2, pp. 165–68.
- 86 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 3, p. 62.
- 87 Ibid., p. 148, emphasis mine.
- 88 Ibid., p. 57.

- 89 Ibid., p. 148.
- 90 Ibid., p. 58.
- 91 Ibid., pp. 57-58.
- 92 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 2, pp. 163-64.
- 93 Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, 'Can the Subaltern Speak?', in Patrick William and Laura Chrisman, eds., *Colonial Discourse and Postcolonial Theory: A Reader*, Columbia University Press, New York, 1994, p. 94.
- 94 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 306.
- 95 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 1, pp. 175-76, n. 1.
- 96 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 41.
- 97 See Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 309. 'During sleep he [the Emperor] is guarded by women slaves, very brave, and highly skilled in the management of bow and other arms.'
- 98 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 177.
- 99 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 312.
- 100 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 274.
- 101 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 318.
- 102 See *ibid.*, p. 425.
- 103 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 3, pp. 195-96. The incident of a slave woman putting a spell on her mistress using a magic doll.
- 104 Ibid., p. 58.
- 105 A rare oblique reference to the mood of the Inquisition in Europe. See Pompa Banerjee, 'Introduction', *Burning Women: Widows, Witches and Early Modern European Travellers in India*, Palgrave MacMillan, 2003.
- 106 Teltscher, 'Indian Women', p. 44.
- 107 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 1, pp. 127-28.
- 108 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 306.
- 109 Tavernier, *Travels*, Vol. 1, p. 58.
- 110 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 93.
- 111 Bernier, *Travels*, p. 82.
- 112 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 2, p. 82.
- 113 Bernier, *Travels*, pp. 404-05.
- 114 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 3, pp. 99-102, emphasis mine.
- 115 The insecurities presented by the wandering mendicant are a constant feature of travel narratives of the seventeenth century.
- 116 Manucci, *Storia*, Vol. 3, pp. 102-03.
- 117 This is an established point by now as the travel narratives of Bernier and Tavernier went through several editions. Ovington, Fryer and all other travel/authors addressed the audience keeping in mind the medium of print. Getting travel narratives printed was a profitable activity as is apparent from Catrou taking control of Manucci's texts in the 1670s and getting them published in his own version.

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